



Armada Kalamunda Group

Emergency Relief Fund Social Work Guideline

1. Purpose

The Emergency Relief Fund (ERF) is funded by the Armada Kalamunda Group (AKG).

The ERF assists patients in crisis with the provision of basic essential needs. The ERF is utilised on compassionate grounds, and to facilitate timely and safe discharge and hospital admission avoidance.

This fund, generally distributed in the form of Woolworths Essential Cards, is supervised by the Social Work Head (or proxy). All Social Workers (SWs), Aboriginal Hospital Liaison Officers (AHLOs) and Welfare staff can request ERF on behalf of their patients via the Social Work Head (or proxy). Welfare Officers (WOs) are to initially discuss the request to access the fund with their Social Work supervisor.

Other forms of ERF such as smart riders, clothes, shoes, food hampers, and other personal items, can be accessed by SWs, AHLOs and WOs on behalf of their patients as required, in accordance with the assessed financial hardship. This form of ERF is managed by WOs however does not require request to access. A regular audit of ERF will be undertaken by WOs, overseen by Senior Social Work staff.

This document guides assessment and access to the ERF for Social Workers, AHLOs, Welfare Officers and Welfare Assistants at AKG.

2. Applicability

This Guideline applies to all SWs, AHLOs, Welfare Officer and Welfare Assistants working across AKG.

3. Guidelines

3.1 Assessment of financial hardship

Patients are identified as having financial concerns when they:

- have a health care card and are experiencing financial hardship.
- receive an income support payment and are experiencing financial hardship.
- are not entitled to receive Centrelink Benefits due to not being an Australian Citizen, however, are experiencing financial hardship.
- have had their Centrelink payments suspended due to non-compliance issues.
- have no family or friends available to provide assistance.
- are unable to access other government and community supports in a timely manner.
- are the victim of family or domestic violence, or other extreme circumstances.

The SWs, AHLOs and/or Welfare Officer will undertake a full assessment of the patient and their family considering:

- source of income
- housing stability
- access to Centrelink Advance and Emergency Payments
- alternative feasible sources of funding or items
- presenting situation
- medical situation and associated expenses
- adverse event
- family support
- family dependents (i.e. young children)

The SWs, AHLO or WO will determine if genuine financial hardship is present and appropriate form of support to meet the patient's needs, in addition to considering referral to community financial support providers for longer term assistance.

The assessment and outcome will be documented in the patient's Digital Medical Record (DMR)

3.2 Types of support provided (pending availability):

- shoes (one pair)
- clothing, located in Mental Health Social Work Office
- personal items such as underwear and toiletries (one set)
- emergency accommodation (for 1 to 2 days if the patient does not have access to family, friend or carer who is able to assist with providing shelter to support discharge of a vulnerable patient or to prevent admission). Director Allied Health approval required
- Woolworths Essential Cards in denominations of \$50, \$20 and \$10 to be used for food, fuel (NB alcohol and tobacco products cannot be purchased with Essentials Cards) other essential items not listed above, as discussed and approved by Social Work Head of Department or AKG Executive where indicated

3.3 Process for provision of support:

Woolworths Essentials gift cards are kept in a lock box in a locked filing cabinet in the SW HOD office. A small number of Essentials Cards will be located in locked boxes in the following specialist areas: Paediatrics, Maternity, Emergency Department. Process for accessing cards in these areas remains the same.

An inventory of allocated funds/ Essential Cards is located at W:\Social Work\AKH\Social Work\Resources, Information\Emergency Relief Fund. The following information is recorded: serial number of individual cards, dollar value, name and UMRN of patient.

Patients are entitled to receive support from the ERF, Woolworth Cards, once per financial year unless in extenuating circumstances as discussed with Social Work Head (or proxy).

No cash to be given to any patient.

The Social Work Head will keep a record of all purchases and receipts and provide acquittals against the fund at the times nominated by AKG.

When providing ERF Woolworth Cards to patients, documentation is required in order to evidence the exchange. The ERF Provision form needs to be signed by the patient and

witnessed by the attending SWs, WOs or AHLO. The form needs to be placed on patient file and uploaded to W drive.

4. Legislative context

The following documents are required to give effect to this policy:

- Health Department of Western Australia (HDWA) [Financial Management Manual: FMM Chapter 6: Expenditure Management](#)

5. Relevant standards

National Safety and Quality Health Service (NSQHS) Standards (second edition):

- Standard 2 – Action 2.6 Sharing decisions and planning care
- The health service organisation has processes for clinicians to partner with patients and/or their substitute decision-maker to plan, communicate, set goals, and make decisions about their current and future care
- Standard 2 – Action 2.10 Communication that supports effective partnerships
- The health service organisation supports clinicians to communicate with patients, carers, families and consumers about health and health care so that:
 - a. Information is provided in a way that meets the needs of patients, carers, families and consumers
 - b. Information provided is easy to understand and use
 - c. The clinical needs of patients are addressed while they are in the health service organisation
 - d. Information needs for ongoing care are provided on discharge

6. References

7. Document owner

Social Work Head of Department

Enquiries relating to this guideline may be directed to:

Title: Head of Department

Department: Social Work

8. Review

This guideline will be reviewed and evaluated as required to ensure relevance and currency. At a minimum it will be reviewed within one (1) year after first issue and at least every three (3) years thereafter.

Version	Effective from	Effective to	Amendment(s)
V3.0	13/03/2025	13/03/2028	1.Purpose - Additional text included to clarify the use of Essentials Cards and other forms of ERF.

			3.2 types of support provided - Removal of: power and gas, pharmacy, rental payments. Reformatting of text for some types of support provided (i.e. clothing “only” removed, addition of separate point for camping equipment Changed the specification of number of cards and key workers who have a small number of cards available to them to just ED and Paeds SSW Addition of “patient details and UMRN is placed next to card number(s) and \$ value of each” 4/6.Approval process – removed reference to P Card Access to other stored items such as clothing in the storage room in Goline building can be accessed and distributed by SW, WOs and AHLOs on weekdays and weekends without the need for approval by Social Work Head (or proxy). 5. Record Keeping/Data Collection - Added: “When providing ERF Woolworth Cards to patients, documentation is required in order to evidence the exchange. The ERF Provision form needs to be signed by the patient and witnessed by the attending SWs, WOs or AHLO. The form needs to be placed on patient file and uploaded to W drive.”
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9. Authorisation

This guideline has been authorised and issued by the Director Allied Health and Ambulatory Care.

Authorised by	Danielle Kilmurray – Director Allied Health and Ambulatory Care
Authorisation date	13/03/2025
Published date	13/03/2025